

TAKING OFF

Her debut film with admirer Kamal Hasan never took off but sexy siren **Laila Nabeel** has managed to get a headstart anyhow. Apart from playing the lead in Partho Ghosh's *Sazaa*, Nabeel will also play a seductress in Shyam Ramsay's *Bhaag Meri Jaan*. But the trained belly dancer, who also gets to shake a leg with Hrithik Roshan in a music album, has bigger dreams. "I want something that is totally performance-driven, like Vidya Balan in *Bhool Bhulaiya*," says Nabeel. Aren't the item numbers performance-driven too?



Country Roads

Hot pants and hot words may have become the norm on MTV's *Roadies*. If all goes well, the new season could have a surprise element. Ravneet Kaur, 18, a potential finalist for the seventh edition, is a salwar kameez-clad gal from Malout village, Punjab. Kaur, whose parents are farmers, dreams of becoming an Air Force pilot. On *Roadies*, she promises to prove that village girls can match up to their city counterparts. "Girls from villages are no less; whether it is in studies or when it comes to winning *Roadies*," says Kaur.



SON ALSO RISES

Venkatraman Ramakrishnan may have hit headlines worldwide for his Nobel Prize but son Raman, 33, will be striking a different note when he is in Mumbai in December. The New York-based cellist, who has performed worldwide and scooped many music awards, will play at the Sangat Music Festival for the third time. Raman, a physics graduate from Harvard, says science and music run through his family's veins.



STEVE J. SHERMAN

Kannada Khan

Here's reason why Salman Khan should lose sleep. Kannada actor Chetan, 25, popularly referred to as the Southern Salman for his shirtless stints in films, is all set to do it again in *Suryakanthi*. Set to be released in December, the film will, once again, show Chetan in his bare-chested avatar. The actor, however, likes to underplay his muscular frame, saying he is "not as big as Salman". Their films may never be on the same subjects, considering Chetan's idea of romance (to read Joseph Conrad and listen to "Bird" Parker's jazz records) is poles apart from Salman's gyrations, but this may well be the face, er body, to watch out for.



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